

Group 4 Design Framework – “Age Matters”

Written by: Jordan Ackemann, Riley Bader, Bemnet Berhe, James Femino, and Diego Mendez

Logic/Theory of Change

By the end of this module, participants will have moved from X to X in their 1 hour together. For example, we do X, to set the foundation for X, for the purpose of X.

Outline

The goal of our facilitation, overarchingly, is to deconstruct intergenerational perspectives, build empathy and adaptable communication, and to highlight the value of elder wisdom as well as youth ideas in the nonprofit space. The facilitation is outlined as follows:

I. Introduction/Warm-Up (14 min)

- a. General discussion of Age Matters chapter and reviewing goals for facilitation (not revealing too much about activities but giving an overview (5 minutes)
 - i. Key Terms
- b. [On a notecard] write down a controversial opinion you have (2 minutes)
- c. Agree/Disagree Line Mini-Activity (7 minutes)
 - i. 5 lines: Strongly Disagree, Slightly Disagree, Neutral, Slightly Agree, Strongly Agree
 - ii. 3 statements for the whole class
 1. “Gen Z has it harder than every other generation.”
 2. “Older people often speak to me in condescending tones/often misunderstand me.”
 3. “Age is important to how I view family/social structures” (dads friend is uncle)
 - iii. Short discussion – why, any personal experiences? (5 minutes)

II. Activity #1 – Generation Goggles Role Play (15 minutes)

- a. [Goal] practicing empathy and adaptable communication across generations. Also examining urgency vs. process.
- b. Separate into groups of 4-5, everyone is assigned roles:
 - i. Early-career professional (young)
 - ii. Mid-career professional (middle-aged)
 - iii. Senior professional (older, in leadership/board member)
- c. Every group has a scenario, every member has 2 key objectives:
 - i. Everyone has to ‘fight’ for both objectives but can only have 1 to truly compromise
- d. ROUND 1: play it out naturally and note tensions (this will be timed, 5min)
- e. ROUND 2: play it out with intentional respect + adaptability (timed, 5min)
 - i. “I” statements

- ii. Align with common interests
- iii. Let people finish completely before speaking + everyone must speak
- f. DEBRIEF – WHOLE CLASS (5 minutes)
 - i. What assumptions did you make the first time?
 - ii. Where did conversation/compromise break down?
 - iii. What changed between rounds?
 - iv. How can this be applied in real settings for you/workplace?

III. Activity #2 – Wisdom and Innovation Exchange (15 min)

- a. [Goal] highlight the value of elder wisdom and younger innovation and reduce or shed light on entitlement/bias
- b. Everyone pair up with someone you haven't spoken to yet in class
- c. ROUND A (5 min)
 - i. Person 1: Share a lesson from your experience that people often overlook
 - ii. Person 2: Listen only, then paraphrase
- d. ROUND B (5 min)
 - i. Person 2: Share a new idea or change people/organizations need to embrace
 - ii. Listen and paraphrase
- e. DEBRIEF – WHOLE CLASS (5 min)
 - i. What surprised you?
 - ii. When did you feel most heard today?
 - iii. How can we best integrate our varied perspectives with respect and dignity into the nonprofit space + greater world?

IV. Closing Thoughts/Questions (1 min)

- a. What came up for you? Was it hard to role play? Anything you realized?

Key Concepts and Skills

- ★ Empathy + understanding different perspectives (across generations and more)
 - Challenging age stereotypes requires intentional communication, awareness, and respect across age groups especially in workplaces
 - SKILL: put yourself in someone else's shoes + be curious
- ★ Identifying bias or entitlement – ageism is widespread and normalized often
 - Communication can reflect and reinforce age bias
- ★ Understanding age as a social identity and its impact – age differences are socially meaningful and not neutral
 - Dress
 - Views on the world
 - Cultures: putting heavy stress on age v.s. not at all

Learning Environment

Directions to Instructors

Key things to consider:

- Share personal anecdotes/experiences where possible, particularly during introduction

Description of Module

The age matters module is focused on how intergenerational communication and biases play out in today's world. It studies age as a social identity that impacts other aspects of our identity, lives, perspectives, and reputation in the working environment.

Description of Activities

The first activity of this module is a role-playing activity, to encourage participants to put themselves into another person's shoes and get into character to more naturally simulate conversation. In groups, participants play out a work situation as their respective characters with their individual objectives internal, and aim to come to a working compromise within the first five minutes. The limited time is intentional to make things even more on the spot. Then, facilitators implement some guidelines for effective communication and listening. In round 2, participants play out the same scenario from where they left off (starting with what was most problematic) and use these tools to come to a cleaner compromise. The whole group then comes back together to share their insights – what worked, what was most difficult, and anything they learned from shifting to using new adaptable communication tools.

The second activity is one-on-one. Each participant gets a partner, someone ideally who is different in some way from them (so men with women or older with younger or white with another race). At the beginning of the workshop, everyone wrote down one “controversial” opinion they had to get them thinking. Now, for round A, person 1 shares with person 2 a lesson or approach they take with them they believe most people overlook. Person 2 just listens, and then paraphrases what they learned after person 1 has finished. Then, in round B, person 2 shares a new idea or change they believe people/organizations need to embrace in today's world more while person 1 listens, then paraphrases. The whole group then comes back together to reflect – when did they feel most heard? How can we best integrate perspectives across generations without sacrificing the value of all perspectives in the nonprofit space?

Contexts for Implementation

This workshop can be used in many contexts, including but not limited to:

- Nonprofit staff and volunteers
- Any other workplace where multiple generations work together
- Random groups of students or just people to study bias and age as a social identity

Resources for Content

- ☐ The Culture Map Chapter 8: Age Matters
- ☐ Character sheets
- ☐ More reading?

Resources for Instruction

- ☐ Notecards
- ☐ Pens at each table
- ☐ Whiteboard/markers
- ☐ Tape (optional) for agree/disagree lines
- ☐ Printed scenarios for activity 1
- ☐ Printed role assignments for activity 1
- ☐ Projector

Assessments

How to assess that people are using the skills + terminology correctly.

- EX: Generational cohorts, social identity of age